

The categorical imperative



Kant developed his ideas of ‘transcendental idealism’ into a comprehensive system of philosophy that included epistemology, metaphysics and ethics. The cornerstone of his moral philosophy was a belief that as rational creatures, we have innate concepts of good and bad, and the free will to make moral choices. But he broke with tradition and argued that morality should be judged on intentions or motives, not consequences. If there is a valid reason that something is right or wrong, he believed, then it must be *universally* valid. Morality is based on reason, just as science is, and moral laws, like the laws of physics, can have no exceptions. Kant famously

expressed this categorical imperative as ‘Act only according to maxims which you can will also to be universal laws’, later adding the notion that it is always wrong to treat others as simply a means to an end. The idea of universal moral laws may be attractive, but it is as hard to justify as purely consequentialist ethics. For example, if we believe lying is always wrong, then is it morally bad to lie to protect the runaway slave we are hiding?